

The Small-Scale Experimentation Guide

You will design and conduct a small-scale experiment (SSEs) in which you will apply and test **the impact of a specific change in your behavior on relevant outcomes that are directly or indirectly related to your individual performance**. Preferably, you will focus on behaviors related to leadership/followership context, but it can also be in other areas of your life, as long as you focus on a key behavioral challenge.

While experiment may sound like a big word, the idea is for you to test or pilot small changes or interventions. You will design your SSE using an evidence-based methodology. Hence, conducting such SSE has two main goals. First, it invites you to establish a close link between the content of the course and your actual leadership practice. Second, it lets you experience a powerful tool which you can use to continue developing yourself as a leader. You will report and reflect on the results of your SSE in your individual assignment. For a more detailed explanation of why this is a good idea, you can turn here: <https://medium.com/accelerated-intelligence/forget-about-the-10-000-hour-rule-7b7a39343523>

You will conduct your SSE using the following steps:

Step 1. Identify your learning objective.

Think about what you would really like to change. What is the “ONE” thing that could potentially hold you back from realizing your potential? Focus on your own behaviors and outcomes (e.g., your confidence level, the efficiency with which you work with others, your ability to manage multiple tasks, your tendency to avoid conflict, being scared to speak up in a large group, pleasing others).

Importantly, you need to address a learning objective which is very important and relevant to you. Consider something that is currently not going well or bothering you, or look at aspects of the course that inspire you.

Example: You often get feedback that during team meetings, you are the one who is constantly talking, insisting on one’s own ideas, and not letting others share their opinions. This feedback also relates to one of your leadership development goals which is becoming a more inclusive leader.

Hence, your learning objective is *to become more open to others’ ideas and opinions*.

Step 2. Identify your new behavior and develop your hypothesis.

After you have identified your learning objective, you need to come up with a new behavior that you will introduce in order to achieve your learning objective. First, write down and describe **in detail** how your current behaviors contribute to the challenge you described in Step 1. For example, if the challenge that bothers you is avoiding conflict and not being able to stand your ground, then think about a few instances where that issue came up and describe your behavior in those situations. Then, hypothesize about what alternative behaviors you could exhibit and what the results of those behaviors may be. Ideally, you’ll do so by using an evidence-

based approach. That is, to come up with a new behavior, you need to use the theories or findings discussed in this course or in literature that is relevant to this course.

Choose one particular behavior you would like to introduce. Importantly, introduce only one new behavior. Otherwise, if you introduce multiple changes, it will be hard to conclude which one is driving the effects that you observe. **While you need to introduce only one new behavior, you need to make sure that this behavior is really challenging for you and pushes you to go out of your comfort zone. Do not play safe!**

Once you have identified your new behavior, build a hypothesis reflecting on how you will address your learning objective. A good hypothesis is a proposition that you can test.

Example: After reviewing the relevant literature on the topic, you have decided to practice active listening. Active listening implies giving your team members your undivided attention, asking clarifying questions, and demonstrating that you are listening through your body language and other non-verbal cues.

Hypothesis: *Practicing active listening will make me more open to others' ideas and opinions.*

Step 3. Plan when and where you will test your new behavior. Identify the period in which you will try out your new behavior. Plan your SSE in a way that you can practice your new behavior repeatedly for 2 weeks. Overall, your goal should be to try out your new behavior as many times as possible in order to be able to confidently conclude whether it has an impact on your key outcome (i.e., your learning objective). You should also identify the setting in which you will practice this new behavior (e.g., during team meetings, during classes, etc.).

In case that after the first week, you see that your behavior is not helping you at all and/or you feel extremely uncomfortable displaying it, you can change your new behavior and practice another one.

Step 4. Assign at least one person to monitor your progress and get feedback from.

Once you have finalized the design of your SSE, assign one person from the relevant context who will provide you feedback about the design of your experiment. This person will also monitor your progress and can give you feedback on your new behavior and on whether you are achieving your learning objective after you have conducted your experiment.

When choosing your observer, ask people who can directly observe your behavior and the issue you are trying to address.

Step 5. Run your SSE. Try out your new behavior for 2 weeks and carefully observe the impact of this new behavior on your learning objective. Try to use some indicators, either objective (e.g., the number of times that more silent members of

your team spoke up) or subjective (e.g., your own observations and feedback from your observer), which would allow you to conclude whether your new behavior is effective in addressing your learning objective. During this period, also observe how this new behavior makes you feel or think about yourself and/or your role as a team member or team leader.

Step 6. Reflect on the results of your SSE in your individual assignment.

To assess the effectiveness of your new behavior, reflect on the results of your SSE by answering the following questions:

1. What did you observe during your SSE? What did the observer notice during the SSE? Were your observations similar or different? What worked well, and what did not? Did you feel comfortable or uncomfortable displaying this new behavior? How challenging did you find to practice your new behavior? How did your behavior or reactions change during the SSE? How did the SSE make you feel? What kind of emotions did you experience during the SSE?
2. To what extent did you achieve your learning objective? Was your hypothesis supported? If not, why do you think your new behavior was not effective in addressing your learning objective?
3. What do the outcomes of your SSE mean for your future behavior? How will you ensure your new behavior is put into practice in your everyday life? If your new behavior was not effective, what other new behaviors you may try out to address your learning objective?

Step 7. Submit a max 2-page report that describes all the previous 6 steps

Submit the report on 24 of April.